Lots of bright-coloured black and red pots and jars, iron objects such as arrowheads, lances and knife-blades, and animal bones were buried with the dead. Undressed granite menhirs were also found here, and this is one reason why these people in Maski have been given the appellation ‘megalithic-building people’. The monoliths, though, were not associated with funerary deposits, so what exactly they signified remains unknown. There is also uncertainty about what the uses to which some of the objects were put, as for instance certain mysterious-looking spheroidal stone balls. In the opinion of the excavator, these could have been sling-stones, or ‘bolas’, for killing fast-moving game. They could also well have been playthings since two of them were buried with a child, placed near its feet. Perhaps dear to the child, they ‘were placed along with the dead body as part of the funeral furnishings.’[35] Other favourite toys of the children of Maski have also been found in such graves. One of these, placed in a grave pit with a child’s body, is a painted disc that resembles a hopscotch diagram.

Maski’s structurally unprepossessing settlement pattern can give the mistaken impression that this was an isolated interior village. Scholars who know the area’s history point to the presence of all kinds of artefacts and inscriptions here which capture its links with other regions in the subcontinent and beyond. An early hint of this, in all likelihood before the time of Ashoka, is a terracotta cylinder seal engraved with a man driving an elephant. While the elephant is characteristically Indian, the man’s ‘radiating’ headdress and the contours of his mouth, as also the seal’s cylindrical shape, suggest strong affinities with Mesopotamia.[36] Such cylinder seals were known to occur more frequently in the third millennium cities of the Indus civilization further north, at places like Mohenjodaro and Chanhudaro. Did a merchant trading goods between Mesopotamia and India visit this region? If yes, what was the trader looking for in the Maski